SAMARA HOUSE
(John E. and Catherine E. Christian House)
1301 Woodland Avenue
West Lafayette
Tippecanoe County
Indiana

HABS IN-247
HABS IN-247

PHOTOGRAPHS

WRITTEN HISTORICAL AND DESCRIPTIVE DATA

REDUCED COPIES OF MEASURED DRAWINGS

FIELD RECORDS

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY
National Park Service
U.S. Department of the Interior
1849 C Street NW
Washington, DC 20240-0001

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY

SAMARA HOUSE
(John E & Catherine E Christian House)

HABS No: IN-247

LOCATION: 1301 Woodland Avenue, West Lafayette, Tippecanoe County, IN 47906. Lat: 40.438585 Long: -86.916583 (Center of Residence, Google Earth, Simple Cylindrical Projection, WGS84).

PRESENT OWNER: John E Christian Foundation. This is the name of the foundation set up to maintain the property and they are the current occupants.

PRESENT USE: The house is currently undergoing restoration to be preserved as a cultural artifact. There are plans to open the site as a museum for the public. The intention of the Trust is to disseminate information about Wright's unique Usonian design and tell the story of the Christian's as they endeavored to build their home in collaboration with a gifted architect.

SIGNIFICANCE: The Samara House is a dwelling designed by Frank Lloyd Wright in the late 1950s. It is an excellent example of a "Usonian" style of the house designed by the world-renowned architect. Wright designed the architecture, landscape on the property, and was responsible for the fixed as well as movable furniture. The house stands testament today to Wright's Usonian ideals and can be considered a magnificent example of his later work. It has been designated a National Historic Landmark structure in 2015. It is also listed in the Indiana Register of Historic Sites and Structures as of April 22, 1992, and in the National Register of Historic Places on December 16, 1992.

HISTORIANS: Hongxi Yin, Junhao Li, Huzefa Jawadwala; Washington University in St. Louis

PART I: HISTORICAL INFORMATION

A: PHYSICAL HISTORY:

1. **DATE OF ERECTION:** The house began construction in April 1955. The Christian's moved into their house in September 1956.[1]

2. **ARCHITECT:** The house was designed by Frank Llyod Wright (1867-1959). He was a prolific American architect, and some would argue the greatest designer and visionary of his era. He is heralded by architectural historians and has been described as, "the vital link between the past and the future."[2] Samara is an excellent example of a Usonian House.

---

[1] Scott W. Perkins and Camille B. Fife, "SAMARA (JOHN E. CATHERINE E. CHRISTIAN HOUSE) NHL Nomination Document" (National Historic Landmarks Program, March 2014).

[2] Handlin P. David, *American Architecture*, Second Edition, Thames and Hudson World of Art (Singapore: Thames and Hudson, 2004).

USONIA stands for, 'United States of North America and is describing small, free-standing houses for "true Americans."[3] The earliest known use of this word is in an essay written by an American author James Duff Law. The essay is part of a collection called 'Here and there in two hemispheres' published in 1903. In that he quotes a letter he has written saying: "We of the United States, in justice to Canadians and Mexicans, have no right to use the title 'Americans' when referring to matters pertaining exclusively to ourselves."[4]

The Usonian style had a set of common features that although Wright did not codify in a formal document, by observing various houses designed by him in this period, one can summarize the highlights. The structures were always designed on specific grid sizes. It was a rectangular grid at most times, but he has also used a hexagonal and circular grid for some homes. The houses were single-story small structures without a basement or higher floor to minimize costs. When mechanical systems were just being introduced in buildings, Wright pioneered the homes with sophisticated underfloor radiant heating systems. The roofs were simple flat slabs with cantilevered overhangs to provide sun-shading and create outdoor patios.

The floor plans were open, and the living room was centered around a central fireplace or hearth with few interior walls, thus minimizing connecting corridor space. The floor slabs often bared imprints of the grid and were poured in a trademark reddish-brown hue, thus replicating the grid pattern from his drawings. He designed an extended roof slab with a small brick pier outside the front door to shelter the automobile. This extended roof was called the 'carport.' He was against building a garage with walls as it was an avoidable expense, and he was known to have quipped once, "This is a modern-day horse, and you do not need to build a stable to prevent someone from driving it away without your permission."

He would often design huge glass windows in the living rooms in the ideal orientation with proper shading considerations. For example: overhanging roofs with appropriate orientation, to let in light in the early morning and evening while reducing heat gain in the afternoon. His houses also often featured high set bands of clerestory windows, which maximized sunlight in the winter months and reduced glare in the summer as deep roof overhangs protected them. He used natural materials like wood, brick, and stone. His architectural designs were also accompanied by unique pieces of sculpture, customized built-in furniture, and roof fascia details.

3. **OWNERS & USES:** The house was owned by the Christians. In 1991 a chain of succession was established for the future ownership and stewardship of the house after their passing. Since Dr Christian's death it is now owned by the John E. Christian Family Memorial Trust Inc. This was established by Dr Christian and his daughter Linda to ensure that the house is protected in perpetuity.[5]

---

[3] Heinz, *The Vision of Frank Lloyd Wright, First Edition, Chartwell Books, (Hong Kong, 2001).*
[4] "Frank Lloyd Wright," in *Wikipedia*, October 17, 2020, https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Frank_Lloyd_Wright&oldid=984043806.
[5] Perkins and Fife, "SAMARA (JOHN E. CATHERINE E. CHRISTIAN HOUSE) NHL Nomination Document."

4. **BUILDER, CONTRACTOR SUPPLIERS:** Construction work was performed by a local contractor, A. Frank Woods (1892-1967). His foreman was Donald Martin. The work was supervised by Wright's apprentice Edward Kipta (1927-1996). He relocated to West Lafayette and served as the clerk of works. Several skilled craftsmen and artisans contributed to the project in fulfilling Wright's vision.[6]

5. **ORIGINAL PLANS AND CONSTRUCTION:** The Christians at the outset informed Wright that they had limited funds. This resulted in them taking possession of their home in September 1956. They continued to work with various craftsmen in conjunction with Wright's studio to commission the various custom designed pieces of furniture and interior fabrics as funds become available.

6. **ALTERATIONS AND ADDITIONS:** The roof slabs when the house was originally completed were bare and finished with plaster. Currently a geometric copper fascia whose design is derived from the Samara motif as per Wright's specifications has been added to the roof.

B: HISTORICAL CONTEXT:

In 1950, Dr. and Mrs. Christian purchased lot Number Eight in the Woodland Heights addition to the City of West Lafayette, Indiana, from the Purdue University Research Foundation. The site is a triangular lot slightly larger than one acre with a fourteen-foot drop in elevation from west to east. The adjacent properties to the southeast of the Christians' lot sweep steeply upward, creating a valley in a wooded ravine.

Mrs. Christian learned of Wright after visiting the planned Usonia town in Pleasantville, New York state. This town was planned as a community of small homes in abundant nature. She was taken with the concept and was keen for Wright to design their home. Following some persuasion and a random phone conversation, Wright took on the commission.

However, he impressed upon his clients that although they could not afford to build his entire design for the property initially, they would bring his vision to life piecemeal strictly according to his drawings. The Christians built the house and started residing at the property in 1956 and slowly commissioned all the related furniture, light fixtures, ornamental rugs, and fascia details to Wright's specifications as additional funds become available. They closely worked with his wife, Olgivanna Lloyd Wright, and Wright's school of Architecture at Taliesin after his passing in 1959 to fulfill his exacting design vision. The house stands testament today to Wright's Usonian ideals and can be considered a magnificent example of his later work.[7]

PART II: ARCHITECTURAL INFORMATION

[6] Perkins and Fife.
[7] Linda Eales, "The Story of Samara House" (Video lecture, Via Video conferencing, September 17, 2020).

A: GENERAL STATEMENT:

1. **ARCHITECTURAL CHARACTER:** The Samara is a unique building in an otherwise conventional single-family suburban neighborhood. Wright laid out the house on a 4x4' square grid comprising a large living cum dining room, a kitchen, two bedrooms, a study and two bathrooms. The area of the house was 2200 sq. ft.

   One encounters a stylized letterbox and a sleek metal entry gate design to approach the house from Woodland avenue. The site is heavily contoured and has a significant rise from the street. Samara is located on top of the slope with a small brick driveway leading up to the top. The backyard opens to a little wooded valley. As the Christians waited for their plans to be finalized by Wright, they nurtured the existing trees and planted more saplings on their land.

   As one walks up the driveway to the house, we face the sleek carport where Wright intended the automobile to be parked. The carport is a simple slab extending from the main building's roof and supported by a tiny, enclosed room similar in scale to an outhouse or tool storage room. Samara's main door leads into the living room, the central living space in the house. He creates a long built-in sofa to one side of the wall, with a slight elevation change from the main floor, creating tiered seating. The living room becomes an ideal space where the professors can address student assemble. He also designed small square cuboidal cushioned seats and similarly proportioned geometric center table pieces. These can be assembled to create a large table or taken apart for multiple people to sit. He created a customized piece to house a contemporary music speaker of the time.

   The Christians liked to throw parties, and this design feature shows us that Wright understood his clients and designed to fulfill all their requirements.[8] The living room's centerpiece is a large fireplace and chimney, which leads one to the dining room and open kitchen. The spaces are meant to be fluid and without formal doors or separations. Wright provides collapsible doors to isolate the kitchen from the dining room. The living and dining rooms both provide access to the outside with tall floor-to-ceiling openable glass doors. There is a small patio outside the living room which is protected by deep roof overhangs. The dining room opens to the 'lanai'- a small, landscaped area of the backyard. From the main door, the other path leads to private areas of the house. There is a guest bedroom and a larger master bedroom on the other side of the house. These also connect to the outside but are more protected and offer more privacy from the landscaped backyard. The kitchen features room for a state-of-the-art dishwasher, refrigerator, and other modern appliances.

2. **CONDITION OF FABRIC:** The house as noted above is in a wooded lawn. The greenery is found to be overgrown in some places and threatens to overshadow the house completely. From the exterior some of the brick walls are in immaculate condition whereas there are certain locations where the brickwork has started to chip and deteriorate. This can be observed in the wall which forms the parapet for the balcony outside the living room. Here one can notice some weather damage in the walls as well as the floor. Most noticeable damage on the house can be observed in the same balcony where there is a large, cantilevered slab forming a partial roof which can be seen clearly deflecting towards the ground. The copper fascia on the roof slab has taken on a nice, aged patina and looks to be in good shape. Overall, there are some additions in the form of external landscape pieces and external features which complement the original design.

[8] Eales.

B: DESCRIPTION OF EXTERIOR

1. **OVERALL DIMENSIONS:** The house is a single storied rectangular-shaped building. The house measures 84' x 40'. Additionally, there is a large overhanging slab which is an extension of the roof slab functioning as a shelter for their car. Wright called this, "The carport." There was curved short wall creating a "lanai - sheltered private outdoor space" accessible from the dining and bedrooms.

2. **FOUNDATIONS:** The foundations are made from reinforced concrete. An earlier draft of the building drawings shows the provision of a basement which after discussions with the Christians was excluded from the final design.

3. **WALLS:** The walls of Samara House are almost entirely built out of a flat deep red colored brick laid as per Wright's specification. These bricks were produced in Attica, Indiana.[9] He specifies the horizontal mortar joint to be deeper and narrower than the vertical joints to create a deep recess. This way gives the appearance of successive bold horizontal lines and emphasizes the horizontal and relative shortness of the structure. The split-level roof slabs also add to this illusion of flatness. Wright was unapologetic about this, and he said that he was inspired by the flatness of the prairie land within which he was designing these houses. He did not feel that architecture always had to be enamored by the vertical. The materials are consistent on the interior and exterior of the building. Most of the interior walls and the fireplace are built from bricks. There is polished mahogany wood used as vertical supports for the tall windows, and the furniture and the paneling for certain parts of the home are made of the same material. The floors are poured concrete with a deep red color set to the characteristic 4' grid, and some areas have a yellow-colored carpet.

4. **STRUCTURAL SYSTEM, FRAMING:** Samara is a masonry dwelling with steel supports for supporting sections of the roof and some glazed wall areas. The walls which are built with brick receive the same treatment on the interior and this subtly hints at the structural members in the house.

5. **CHIMNEYS:** There is a single central chimney placed in the living room. It receives the same horizontal raked red Attica brick treatment as the rest of the house below it.

6. **DOORWAYS AND DOORS:** The main door faces Southeast and because it is perpendicular to the façade it highlights Wright's ideal of allowing visitors to move through the exterior before discovering the entrance. The doorways are all made of mahogany wood.

7. **WINDOWS AND SHUTTERS:** Usonian houses generally featured two solid walls with the remaining filled with large glass windows looking towards nature. This provided the inhabitants an ever-changing vista. Wright tried to frame these outdoor surroundings in his projects. This is most evident in the living room where he opens an entire corner of the house by creating a corner which floor-to ceiling windows. These are L-shaped in plan and create a large opening which brings in lots of natural light into the space.

[9] Perkins and Fife, "SAMARA (JOHN E. CATHERINE E. CHRISTIAN HOUSE) NHL Nomination Document."

Another special window type were the clerestory windows. They created an impression that the roof slabs were floating. Wright specified Philippine mahogany marine trim for the windows.

8. **ROOF:**

   a. **SHAPE, COVERING:** The roof is made of a flat slab. It is split into two levels with the lower level being the datum for the external carport as well as the outdoor roof pergola. The higher roof creates a short rectangular opening which has fixed glass windows which are ornamented in Philippine mahogany. This brings light into selected rooms like the living and dining rooms.

   b. **CORNINCE, EAVES:** Wright designed an angular patinated copper facias treatment for the roof edges. The design of these was also derived from the Samara motif. Samara is a term used for pinecone needles found in the native vegetation of the locality of the house. Wright was inspired by this and designed an angular motif for the project. This motif can be seen on many of the interior trims and fabrics.

C: DESCRIPTION OF INTERIOR

1. **FLOOR PLANS:** The house has a simple rectangular layout. One enters through the main door into a foyer space. This provides access to the private bedrooms on the left and leading right is the large living room space. The living room is bathed in light because of the spectacular southwest façade which is designed with large floor to ceiling openable glass doors. The dining room is accessible from the living room space. It is designed without internal walls and together they create a large, connected interior volume. There is a centrally placed fireplace, behind which are placed the kitchen and utility rooms.

2. **FLOORING:** The floors are made of a reddish hue pigmented concrete. Certain areas of the living room were carpeted.

3. **WALL AND CEILING FINISH:** The interior walls were finished with brick to maintain a continuity in material. Certain sections of the walls are wood paneled. For example, the wall opposite the dining table.

4. **DECORATIVE FEATURES AND TRIM:** Wright designed and specified multiple items of furniture and interior design objects. Wright had designed table lamps, chairs, tables as well as many other related objects which unified the design. He even assisted the Christians in selecting dinnerware for their kitchen. All of the design of the fabrics includes a geometric motif Wright designed based on the winged seeds of pinecone needles which are native to the location of the house.

5. **HARDWARE:** Throughout the house a simple wood block style door hardware is adopted. These were specified by Wright in his drawings.

6. MECHANICAL EQUIPMENT:

a. **Heating, air conditioning, ventilation:** In all his Usonian houses Wright incorporated radiant floors. This system embeds metal pipes under the concrete floor. Through these pipes hot water is circulated which provides heating to the house. Initially the house did not have a dedicated cooling system. In a later addition the Christian's added a cooling unit which was house behind the wall of the carport.

7. **ORIGINAL FURNISHINGS:** Wright specified a color palette and the contractor team worked hard to produce a high level of finish and workmanship. In 1972, the Christians approached the FLW Foundation in Scottsdale Arizona to help update some of the fabrics and upholstery. As seen in the original design of the house the Christians especially Catherine was instrumental in maintaining a cohesive vision for the project. She took multiple photographs of the existing rooms and meticulously presented them as boards to the associates at the foundation and worked with them to choose colors and other fabrics which needed to be updated. The brighter color palette which resulted from these discussions has endured and can be seen today at the house.[10]

   One of the last pieces to be commissioned and realized was a large rug which is placed in the living room area. This was commissioned in 1994 by Dr Christian. The abstract design is meant to show Samara in motion and was designed by Aris Georges, an apprentice at the Frank Llyod School of Architecture. The rug was fabricated by hand in Indonesia and is an extremely beautiful piece.[11]

D: SITE:

1. **HISTORIC LANDSCAPE DESIGN:** Writing in his book, *A Testament,* Wright clarified the relationship between architecture and landscape:

   > Organic architecture sees shelter not only as a quality of space but of spirit, and the prime factor in any concept of building man into his environment as a legitimate feature of it. Thus, environment and building are one. Planting the grounds around the building on the site as well as adorning the building take on new importance as they become features harmonious with the space within-to-be-lived-in. Site, structure, furnishing-decoration too, plantings-all these become as one in organic architecture.[12]

   Therefore, we see that Wright was particularly interested in the landscape design of the house. He was concerned with the overall estate of the project and not just the architectural design in isolation. One example which illustrates this attention to detail is the choice to maintain the site at a lower grade than the busy Northwestern Avenue. Additionally, a series of trees were planted to ensure that the house was not directly visible from the street. This choice of grade as well as the related greenery allowed the house to feel sheltered.

---

[10] Perkins and Fife.
[11] Eales, "The Story of Samara House."
[12] Perkins and Fife, "SAMARA (JOHN E. CATHERINE E. CHRISTIAN HOUSE) NHL Nomination Document."

Dr Christian had a green thumb. Over the years he planted and pruned various species of trees, plants, and shrubs. This allowed the house to create a private woodland atmosphere.

2. **OUTBUILDINGS:** The project does not have any large outbuildings. There is a small tool room created from the hollow wall which supports the slab of the carport. This is treated in the same horizontal red Attica brick as the rest of the house.

PART III: SOURCES OF INFORMATION

A. INTERVIEWS

a. Eales, Linda. "The Story of Samara House." Video lecture, Via Video conferencing, September 17, 2020. Linda Eales is the curator of the Christian Family Memorial Trust.

B. SELECTED SOURCES

a. Published:

Perkins, Scott W., and Camille B. Fife. "SAMARA (JOHN E. CATHERINE E. CHRISTIAN HOUSE) NHL Nomination Document." National Historic Landmarks Program, March 2014.

Curtis J. R. William. *Modern Architecture since 1900*. Third. China: Phaidon, 1996.

Handlin P. David. *American Architecture*. Second Edition. Thames and Hudson World of Art. Singapore: Thames and Hudson, 2004.

Heinz, A. Thomas. *The Vision of Frank Lloyd Wright*. First. Hong Kong: Chartwell Books Inc., 2001.

b. Other:

Mumford, Eric. "Frank Lloyd Wright." Video lecture, Video Conference, October 12, 2020.

Rosenbaum House. "Usonian Architecture." Accessed October 20, 2020. https://www.wrightinalabama.com/usonian-architecture.

Wright, Llyod Frank. "House for Mr. and Mrs. John E Christian." FLW Foundation, 1955.

"Samara House." Accessed October 20, 2020. https://samara-house.org/#about.

Doctor of Arts, University of Albany, Literacy Education M. S., English B. A., Facebook, and Twitter. "About Frank Lloyd Wright's Usonian Architecture." ThoughtCo. Accessed October 20, 2020. https://www.thoughtco.com/usonian-style-home-frank-lloyd-wright-177787

Frank Lloyd Wright." In *Wikipedia*, October 17, 2020. https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Frank_Lloyd_Wright&oldid=984043806.

Encyclopedia Britannica. "Frank Lloyd Wright | Biography, Architecture, & Facts." Accessed October 20, 2020. https://www.britannica.com/biography/Frank-Lloyd-Wright.

ArchDaily. "Frank Lloyd Wright House Saved," January 18, 2014. https://www.archdaily.com/468305/frank-lloyd-wright-house-saved.

"Frank Lloyd Wright's SAMARA." Accessed October 20, 2020. http://www.samara-house.org/welcome.htm.

PART IV. PROJECT INFORMATION:

The field measurements for the documentation of Samara House was undertaken in the Fall of 2020 and the report was compiled by the following summer in May 2021. The work was done by the Washington University in St. Louis, under the direction of Sam Fox School of Design and Visual Arts. The faculty team consisted of Hongxi Yin, InCEES Associate Professor; Eric Mumford, Rebecca and John Voyles Professor of Architecture; and Bob Moore, Senior Lecturer. The Graduate Students Field Team consisted of Huzefa Jawadwala, Junhao Li, Wenzhao Zhang, Dennis Dine, Patrick Murray, Wenfei Gu, Naitian Tian, Xiaofei Feng, Henry Zhang, Yuanwan Huang, Raquele Cardozo, Bing Zhao, Yixuan Wang, and Rubo Sun. The photography was undertaken by Hongxi Yin, Associate Professor, Washington University in St. Louis, in consultation with Meghan L. E. Kirkwood, Assistant Professor, Washington University in St. Louis; and Ryan Yin, Sophomore Student, West Lafayette Jr. /Sr. High School. The Laser Scanning Survey was undertaken by staff from Purdue University, including Arman Habib Thomas, A. Page Professor of Civil Engineering, Lyles School of Civil Engineering. The PhD. students Field Team consisted of Yi Chun Lin, and Seyyed Meghdad Hasheminasab. Ground Penetration Radar was undertaken by Hubo Cai, Professor of Civil Engineering and Construction Engineering and Management, Lyles School of Civil Engineering, working with PhD Field Team student, JungHo Jeon. Serving as Historic Preservation Consultant was Jonathan C. Spodek, FAIA, FAPT, NCARB, Professor of Architecture and Director, Graduate Program in Historic Preservation, Ball State University. Serving as Professional Critic/Review was Harboe Architects, PC; T. Gunny Harboe, FAIA, and Bob Score, AIA. The Laser Scanning Survey and Analysis was performed by Shawn Thompson, Building Point Mid-America (VDC Services Manager).